

Beyond Canvas and Paper:

Italian Jesuits' Ceiling Artworks in and outside Rome

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Abstract

This research paper focuses on two Italian Jesuits and their ceiling art works in and outside Italy, one in Rome and the other in Beijing. Fra Andrea Pozzo created a ceiling fresco, *Glorification of Saint Ignatius*, on nave of Church Sant'Ignazio. The mural presents not only Pozzo's management of *quadratura* effect but also serves as a spiritual preparation for visitors from the outside world to this sacred place. Pozzo created only one standpoint at the middle of the nave to peek the truth of his illusionistic image. This viewing experience corresponds to the one truth belief in Christianity, and the physical sensation unites with the spiritual faith. Giuseppe Castiglione, an Italian Jesuit working in Qing court, created an immersive outdoor experience in an indoor space in

Juanqinzhai(倦勤斋), in the Forbidden City. Castiglione's similar *quadratura* application with one best viewing point, however, turns out to be a distinct experience from Pozzo's fresco. A throne reserved for the retired emperor is placed at the standpoint. This special person receives the full illusion with no additional move, as this seat is his destination. Furthermore, it obtains greater implication than standpoint that it is the seat of power. The privilege of non-moving best view echoes to the emperor's surpassing power to receive tributes and worships.

This research elaborately studies and discusses audience-artwork relationships in the two artworks. The goal of this paper is to discover this relationship in the two ceiling paintings. Pozzo and Castiglione silently guide audiences with their designed viewing experiences that reveal patrons' focus of interests. Hopefully, this research could provide us a chance to review masterpieces with new perspectives.

Artworks attached to wall surfaces obtain unique characteristics from those on portable materials. On one hand, their medium limits their mobility. On the other hand, murals acquire special interactions with audiences because of their immobilized capability. Frescos push viewers approaching the site in person, rather than easel paintings could easily present themselves to audiences in various locations.

Fra Andrea Pozzo, an Italian Jesuit active in the late seventeenth century, developed his masterpiece *Glorification of Saint Ignatius* (Fig. 1) on the ceiling of Church Sant'Ignazio, the second most-important church in Rome. As a characteristic example of the Baroque *quadratura* effect,¹ Pozzo's mural had great influence on illusionistic depictions of interior decorations in later generations. Crossing the Eurasian continent to its east coast, Giuseppe Castiglione served as an imperial painter in the Qing imperial court for over fifty years. As the retirement lounge for Emperor Qianlong in the Forbidden City, Juanqinzhai (倦勤斋, Fig. 2) contains an enormous painting attributed by this western artist from its ceiling to surrounded walls. This massive piece serves as an example of the combination of *quadratura* technique with traditional Chinese elements.

1. For a history of Baroque *quadratura*, see Ingrid Sjöström's *Quadratura: Studies in Italian Ceiling Painting* (Stockholm: Alqvist & Wiksell International, 1978).



Fig.1. Andrea Pozzo, *S.J., Glorification of Saint Ignatius* (1694), Sant'Ignazio, Rome.

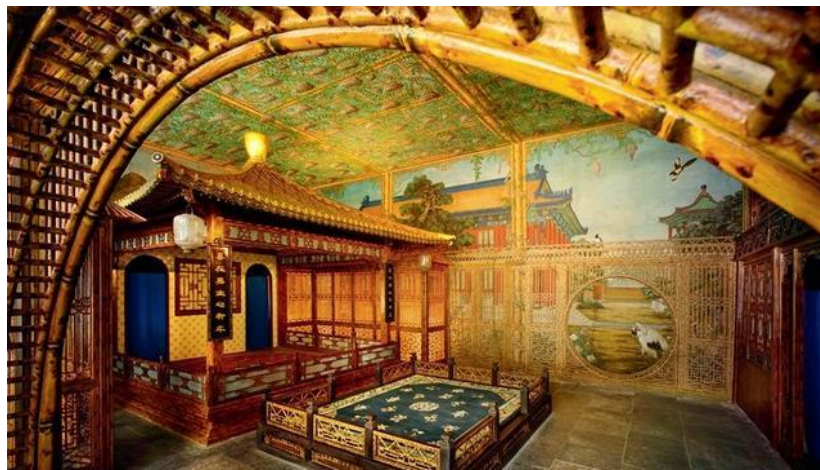


Fig. 2. Studio of Exhaustion from Diligent Service, *Juanqinzhai* 倦勤斋 (1775–1779); scenic illusion with affixed hangings, ink and colors on silk, Palace Museum, Beijing.

Through detailed analysis of the two ceiling artworks in Rome and in Beijing, this paper aims to elaborate the relationship between audiences' viewing experience and the artworks they observe. Via the designed standpoints of these two illusionistic artworks, viewers could develop their own understandings of the pieces through the process of viewing the ceiling paintings. The mobile viewing experience of Pozzo's work and the fixed perspective from Castiglione's ceiling painting implicitly present their patrons' different interests of emphasis.

Walking to the Truth

The Church of Sant'Ignazio is probably the most significant project in Andrea Pozzo's life as a Jesuit and an artist. The young painter had shown talent in painting since his early life. Under the education of the Society of Jesus, Pozzo, at age twenty-three, developed his famous *machina* technique, which is often used for illusionistic decorations and stage setting on festive occasions.² This skill serves as the foundation for other advanced practices, such as *trompe l'oeil* and *quadratura* in Sant'Ignazio's commission, and it assisted Pozzo in developing his knowledge of the relationship between architectures in real life and artificial decorations. Pozzo's talent also helped him gain fame beyond the Catholic community. The Duke of Savoy invited the young artist for a private order after observing his talent. Pozzo, however, turned down the Duke's offer because of his persistent dedication to Christianity. The artist even continued to refuse this outside project after being instructed to do it by the General of the Jesuits. Because of his adamancy, Pozzo was released from the General's directive by Pope Innocent XII.³ Fortunately, the artist eventually obtained the chance to present his full artistic capability in the decoration of Sant'Ignazio.

The *Glorification of Saint Ignatius*, the ceiling mural on the nave of Sant'Ignazio, is Pozzo's magnum opus. The fresco records the moment that Jesus, intentionally placed at

2. Felix Burda-Stengel, Hans Belting, and Felix Burda-Stengel, *Andrea Pozzo and Video Art* (Philadelphia: Saint Joseph's University Press, 2013), 21.

3. Burda-Stengel, Belting, and Burda-Stengel, *Andrea Pozzo and Video Art*, 23.

the center, welcomes Saint Ignatius to heaven. Lit strongly by the slightly opened sky, Christ, bearing an oversized cross, meets the Saint. As the founder of the Society of Jesus, Saint Ignatius sent out missionaries all over the world. Under this circumstance, the four continents, visually located beneath the two central figures, give a double meaning. First, the astonishing illusion of the enlarged interior space appears as the embodiment of the glorification of Jesus, that the four continents are bathing in. Pozzo creates an extended illusionistic space that naturally combines the actual architectural components and fictive decorations. The artist produces actual windows and the four continents images as the foreground, and he painted pillars as the middle ground, while the background consists of the two main figures and the opened sky.⁴ Natural lights from seven surrounding windows together with parallel lines of painted buildings form a focal point on Jesus, directing the audience's attention immediately on the main figure. The four continents sit on the base of orthogonals that serve as the supporters of this glorification. The naturalistic unity of reality and imaginary reveals Pozzo's exquisite precision of understanding architecture and artistic techniques. Second, the four continents serve as the witnesses of this epic moment. Visitors to Sant' Ignazio come from one of the four depicted areas. These images serve as supports for the moment of illumination in the ceiling mural. Meanwhile, the continents, because they are the closest to the audience of any part of the work, also arouse the audience's sense of belongingness and connection. This sensation breaks the boundary of fiction, delivering

4. Katherine Wheeler, "Fictive and Real Architecture: A Preliminary Drawing for Andrea Pozzo's Vault Fresco at Sant' Ignazio, Rome," *Thresholds* 28 (2005): 104.

simultaneous feeling of glorified from observing this moment across the frame into the real world. It is as if audience members are the painted figures in the four continents, witnessing as Saint Ignatius is accepted by Jesus.

The visual function of this ceiling fresco is closely connected with the practical function of the nave, which is located beneath this artwork. The primary role of the nave is physical connection: it serves as the pathway bringing visitors from the main entrance to the altar. The mural located on the nave provides a similar effect: to prepare visitors spiritually for the sacred spot. To achieve this effect, Pozzo applied a horizontal perspective, an illusionistic presentation often used on ceilings and vaults, in the Sant' Ignazio project.⁵ When viewed from a certain point, this technique creates an illusionistic three-dimensional effect on a two-dimensional surface that extends the interior space with vivid artificial decorations. The realistic illusion, however, can only exist in a limited area. Once the audience walks away from the primary viewing point, they lose the effect of realism. Pozzo, the master of the *quadratura* effect, overcame this problem by making it part of the essential viewing into an essential viewing process of this ceiling fresco.

The artist delivers a clear metaphorical message through the physical effect in which the closer the audience can be to the central point, the better they will enjoy the realistic illusion. Starting from the entrance, visitors experience the least effective perspective (Fig. 3) and move toward the most realistic illusion at the central point. Felix

5. Wheeler, "Fictive and Real Architecture," 102.

Burda-Stengel describes this viewing experience in his publication, *Andrea Pozzo and Video Art*.⁶ “Thus, the observer enters the space of the artwork when entering the space of the installation. His movement through the installation is at the same time a movement through the space of the artwork. Observer-space and artwork-space become one. The virtual space of the artwork has been ‘installed’ in the real space.”

Going through this circuitous viewing process,⁷ audiences use their own personal experiences to understand the significance of approaching God. Only at the central point, located directly beneath Jesus, can one enjoy the most realistic image of this artwork. the metaphor of this visual effect conveys the message of the Catholic religion, which advocates belief in the one true God. The simultaneous effect now links visual truth with religious truth that “the only certain knowledge can be found in God.”⁸

6. Burda-Stengel, Belting, and Burda-Stengel, *Andrea Pozzo and Video Art*, 3–4.

7. Kirsti Andersen, “The Master of Painted Architecture: Andrea Pozzo, S. J. and His Treatise on Perspective,” *Geometrical Objects Archimedes*, (2014): 165–188.

8. Burda-Stengel, Belting, and Burda-Stengel, *Andrea Pozzo and Video Art*, 35.

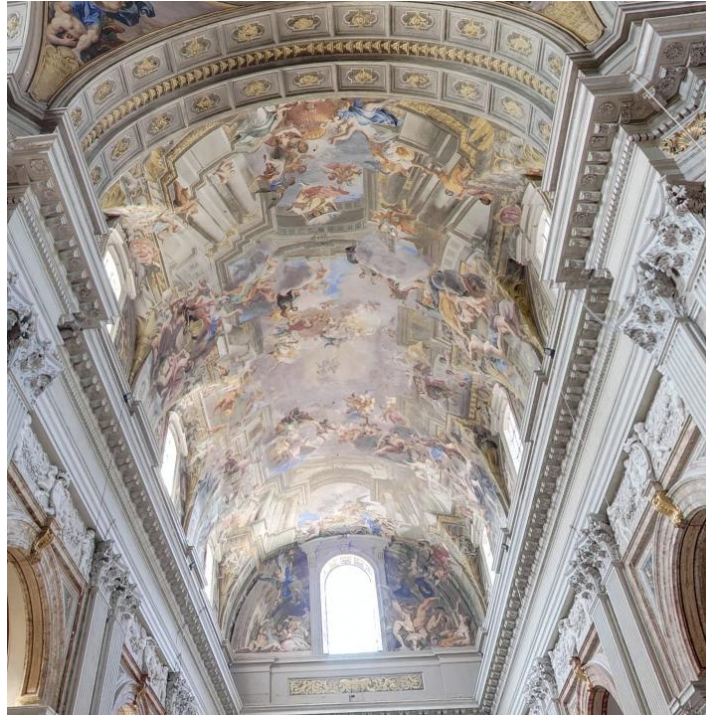


Fig. 3. Less realistic perspective as seen from the choir area, Sant' Ignazio, Rome

Pozzo's work quickly drew numerous followers of his technique. The artist's treatise, *Perspective of Painters and Architects*, was reprinted and translated into other languages after its original edition in Latin and Italian in 1693.⁹ This publication recorded and explained his practice of illusionistic effects in his works. His ceiling fresco of Sant' Ignazio was an inspiration for many other ceiling paintings because the painting combines with the architecture naturally and transforms the interior space.¹⁰

Seat of Receiving

Of all the Western painters in Chinese history, Giuseppe Castiglione is recognized as one of the most influential. He combined Western painting techniques with traditional

9. Burda-Stengel, Belting, and Burda-Stengel, *Andrea Pozzo and Video Art*, 33.

10. Wheeler, "Fictive and Real Architecture," 100.

Chinese style, catering to the taste of his imperial patrons. Castiglione, an Italian Jesuit painter who held the position of Western court painter for the longest period in Qing history, served in the Forbidden City for three emperors: Kangxi, Yongzheng, and Qianlong. While the artist was not the first to introduce perspective painting into the ancient East,¹¹ he was the one popularized it.

The illusionistic fantasy that Castiglione created in Qianlong's retirement lounge is considered an Eastern successor to Pozzo's interior decoration.¹² Although there is no written documentation recording Castiglione's visit to Sant' Ignazio, the interior decoration of the Studio for Exhaustion from Diligent Service (*juanqinzhai*, 倦勤斋) is indeed the most famous surviving example of applying perspective to Eastern themes. The location was a relaxation space for Emperor Qianlong after his abdication from the throne. Located at the northeast corner of the Forbidden City, the lounge holds one of the four existing theater stages with Castiglione's immersive illusions.¹³ The artist applied his skills in animal studies and paintings of birds and flowers as well as architecture to an extreme degree in this scenic illusion painting (*tongjinhua*, 通景画). The direct

11. John R. Finlay, "The Qianlong Emperor's Western Vistas: Linear Perspective and Trompe l'Oeil Illusion in the European Palaces of the Yuanming Yuan." *Bulletin de l'Ecole Française d'Extrême-Orient* 1, (2007): 159. doi:10.3406/befeo.2007.6068.

12. Kristina Kleutghen, "Bring Art to Life: Giuseppe Castiglione and Scenic Illusion Painting" in *Shen Bi Dan Qing: Lang Shining Lai Hua San Bai Nian Te Zhan = Portrayals from a Brush Divine: A Special Exhibition on the Tricentennial of Giuseppe Castiglione's Arrival in China*, ed. Donald E. Brix and Giuseppe Castiglione (Location: National Palace Museum, 2015), 326–327.

13. Finlay, "The Qianlong Emperor's Western Vistas," 159.

translation of the term means “to connect, cross into, or move through” (*tong* 通), “scenes” (*jing* 景), and “painting” (*hua* 画). Kristina Kleutghen further explains the application of this portraiture in Castiglione’s time period:

In the eighteenth century for these monumental illusionistic paintings grounded in imported linear perspective native terminology was prioritized over the foreign to contextualize these works firmly with Chinese tradition. . . . ‘Scenic illusion painting’ aims instead to convey the illusionistic viewing experience inherent in the original term and in the paintings while sustaining the specific cultural context of late imperial China.¹⁴

In other words, this painting delivers a similar visual experience as Pozzo did with the *quadratura* technique. The visual continuity from architecture to paintings transforms the interior space. As a court painter in China, Castiglione applied this Western skill to Eastern mediums. Unlike Pozzo, who painted his fresco directly on the surface of the church, Castiglione applied his artwork on large pieces of silk, a traditional medium in classic Chinese artworks, then pasted them on the walls. As the oldest surviving painting using this technique, the Lounge of Retirement’s interior decoration brings audiences to the world of illusion.

Discussions on the attribution of this artwork have been a continued argument for scholars. Some argue that the *Juanqingzhai* was actually done by Youxue Wang, a student

14. Kleutghen, “Bring Art to Life,” 326.

and colleague of Castiglione, saying the Italian Jesuit died eight years prior to the start of the lounge's decoration. Other scholars, however, make two counterarguments. First, after analyzing various artworks attributed to Youxue Wang, they have said that the Chinese painter could not achieve such a realistic illusionary effect as his master. Secondly, Castiglione created identical scenic illusion paintings for other palaces.¹⁵ Even though we have lost these material objects, the paintings that Castiglione created previously are identified as similar to those in the Lounge of Retirement from the pictorial and literary descriptions. Regardless, there is no doubt about this Italian Jesuit's had contributions to this massive art piece.

In this interior space, Castiglione emphasizes the application of symmetry between objects. At the entrance, two moon gates echo each other; one physically introduces audiences into the lounge, and the other guides viewers into the extended pictorial space. Although both visually deliver bamboo quality, interestingly, all the furniture that appears to be made of bamboo is actually made of *Phoebe zhennan*, a precious wood. The climate in northern China is too dry for bamboo, which is normally found in southern areas. Yet Emperor Qianlong had a special affection for bamboo. To please the emperor, craftsmen drew bamboo patterns on the wood. The bamboo pattern continues from the gates and fences to the space overhead. A bamboo pergola with wisteria covers the entire ceiling. Countless purple flowers grow across trellises, transforming this indoor room to an outdoor

15. 李启乐, and 董建中. "通景画与郎世宁遗产研究." 故宫博物院院刊 3, (2012): 77–88.

space. Other images are elegantly depicted next to the painted moon gate. As a symbol of longevity, a red-crowned crane is standing next to the gate. At that time, attendants of the court would place the actual birds next to the moon gate in real life.¹⁶ All these visual elements together compose a strong mirroring effect that limits the audience's ability to discern fiction from reality.

Similar to Pozzo's ceiling fresco, the Lounge of Retirement also has an ideal viewing point, marked with a raised platform. Located at the center of the room, it is reserved only for the emperor's use. However, compared with Pozzo's mural, which has a moving visual experience, this spot appears with its distinctive character because it is the point of receiving, which is not meant to be experienced through movement and change but in one particular spot. It is not meant to be experienced through movement and change but in one particular spot. This part of the lounge is designed as the theater place, where the emperor could enjoy operas. From this spot, he could enjoy the illusionistic painting on his right along with the reality of that illusion on his left. Without moving, all images, fictive and real, come to this point. This spot, therefore, contains a double meaning: it physically provides an ideal viewing point for the entire interior decoration and the visual privilege of this spot also connects with the high position of the retired emperor. The fact that all images come to that seat connects to the real actions of people, such as pilgrims who would travel to the imperial palace to pay respect to the emperor. The seat of receiving,

16. Professor Patricia Berger mentioned this in her Classical Painting Tradition in China course held in Spring 2018.

therefore, grants the privilege of requiring no mobility—the emperor is the one standing on the top of the hierarchy.

Conclusion

Including audiences as part of artworks may appear to be a modern artistic theory; however, by analyzing audiences' visual experiences of two ceiling artworks, this paper brings a new perspective on the viewer–object relationship. Hundreds of years ago, Pozzo and Castiglione created works that also considered audiences' viewing process. Each artist customized the standpoints of his painting based on the patron's interest. One used perspective to guide visitors through the nave to the altar. The other emphasized on the political vantage of the emperor by applying fictive and real visual experiences.

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